

Big Muddy Touring — Destinations Map

Written 2026-04-29. Voice: admin documentation. Built on `docs/presentations/plan-big-muddy-touring.md`. Treats touring as marketing for the Big Muddy ecosystem, not a music-business tour in the conventional sense.

The thesis

Touring is marketing. The Sprinter van is a billboard. Tracy and Amy walking into a bar in Helena or Florence and ordering a drink — that's the marketing. Every show we route is a wedge into a town's bar, restaurant, hotel, and music economy that Big Muddy can convert into Inn guests, Magazine readers, BMA tiny-home prospects, and Records catalog. Pick towns where that conversion is plausible. Skip towns where it isn't, no matter how good the venue is.

That reframes the destination question. We're not chasing rooms full of music fans. We're chasing rooms full of people who would buy what Big Muddy already sells.

Customer profile — who Big Muddy actually serves

Five personas, ranked by acquisition cost and lifetime value:

- 1. The Inn guest (highest LTV, slowest convert)** Couple or solo traveler, 35–65, household income 90k+, booksboutiqueinnsoverhotels.Readsregionaltravelwriting.Doesn'twantachain.WillflyintoJacksonordrivefromMemphis/Nashville/NewOrleansforalongweekendinatown; 3nights, 200/night room rate. They get hooked when they meet Tracy at a bar in Vicksburg and she tells them about the porch.
- 2. The Magazine reader (lowest acquisition cost, no direct revenue)** Subscribes to *Garden & Gun*, *Oxford American*, *Bitter Southerner*. Already loves the South-as-place. Lives anywhere from Brooklyn to Birmingham. Email captures and Instagram follows are the proxy. Not a buyer yet — they're the funnel for everything else.
- 3. The BMA buyer (highest dollar conversion, longest sales cycle)** Two flavors. (a) Retiree, 58–72, sold a house in Atlanta or Austin or Denver, looking for a cooperative-vibe land community in the Deep South with cultural infrastructure. Wants an RV pad or a tiny-home pad, \$500/mo lot or \$80–150k pad-plus-structure. (b) Creative-class semi-remote worker, 40–55, wants a second-home or a writing studio on a quiet acre. Both convert through trust — they have to feel the place, meet the people, hear the music. They don't buy off a website.
- 4. The show attendee (volume play, low margin per head)** Lives within 90 minutes of the venue. Pays \$15–30 at the door. Buys a drink, maybe a t-shirt. Repeat behavior is the value. They become the local audience that fills the Blues Room when a touring act comes through Natchez.
- 5. The corridor partner (B2B, ecosystem multiplier)** Bar owner, restaurateur, boutique inn-keeper, festival programmer. Doesn't pay us — but trades referrals, accommodations, and bookings. The single highest leverage relationship per night-on-the-road. One good bar friendship in Clarksdale is worth ten Instagram followers.

Tour-stop scoring rubric

Each destination is scored 1–5 across five dimensions. Total /25.

Dimension	What we're measuring
Music density	Are there real venues, real audiences, real touring routes? Lower Mississippi / Blues Highway = automatic 4–5.
Big Muddy customer density	Concentration of personas 1–3. Do people who'd book the Inn or buy at BMA actually live or travel here?
Bar + restaurant culture	Is there a walkable downtown where Tracy + Amy can hit 3 bars in a night and meet people? Strip-mall sprawl = 1. Real downtown = 5.
Drive distance from Natchez	Sprinter van logistics. Same-day = 5. Overnight needed = 3. Two-day haul = 1.
"Off the beaten path"	Chase's filter. Cool small town with character vs. generic music-tour stop. Authentic > big.

A town under 15/25 doesn't make the map. A town at 20+ goes in Tier 1 or 2 regardless of size.

The destinations map

TIER 1 — THE CORRIDOR (THE NATURAL BIG MUDDY ROUTE)

These are the towns where the Sprinter van is already pointed. Every dollar spent routing through here returns ecosystem value.

Natchez, MS — 25/25 — home The base. The Inn, the Blues Room, Smoot's, Under-the-Hill Saloon, King's Tavern. We don't tour here, we host. But every touring act we book has a Natchez night.

Vicksburg, MS — 22/25 Same-day drive (1 hr north). River town with real downtown bones. The Mississippi Welcome Center pulls cross-country travelers. Boutique inn density is low, which means the Big Muddy Inn has clean referral capacity. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* 10 South Rooftop Bar (river view, the best bar in town), Walnut Hills Restaurant, Anchuca Mansion bar, Highway 61 Coffeehouse. *Marketing story back:* Vicksburg-to-Natchez is the underrated 90-minute corridor; sell the loop in the Magazine.

Greenville, MS — 18/25 Delta blues anchor, smaller than Clarksdale but real. Highway 61 town. Home of the Mississippi Delta Blues & Heritage Festival in September. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Doe's Eat Place (the original — tamales and steak), Walnut Street, downtown bars are thinner than Clarksdale but the ones there are the real article. *Marketing story:* the Delta-but-quieter angle. Magazine piece on Greenville for travelers who think Clarksdale is "too touristy."

Clarksdale, MS — 24/25 The blues mecca. 3 hr drive. Crossroads of 49 and 61. Ground Zero Blues Club is the named anchor (Morgan Freeman co-owner, real venue, real audience nightly). Red's Lounge for the juke-joint authenticity. Shack Up Inn for lodging — direct competitor and friend, not enemy. We send guests there when we're full; they should send to us. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Ground Zero, Red's, Hooker Grocer & Eatery, Levon's Bar & Grill, the lobby of Shack Up Inn. *Marketing story:* the corridor isn't Clarksdale-only; Natchez is the southern bookend. Pitch this in every Magazine piece about the Blues Trail.

Memphis, TN — 23/25 Corridor anchor north. 4.5 hr drive from Natchez. Real urban density, real venue infrastructure. Hi-Tone Cafe (verified, alt-music venue), Lafayette's Music Room, Wild Bill's juke joint, B.B. King's on Beale. Memphis is too big to "do" — pick a neighborhood (Cooper-Young or Crosstown) and own it. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Hi-Tone, Earnestine & Hazel's (legendary dive), the Beauty Shop in Cooper-Young, Cafe Eclectic. *Marketing story:* Memphis is the mouth of the corridor; Natchez is its quiet end. Sell weekend trips that hit both. Build a referral relationship with one boutique Memphis hotel.

Helena, AR — 20/25 Across the river from Clarksdale. Home of the King Biscuit Blues Festival (October, 4 days, ~80k attendees). Off-tour the rest of the year, which is the play — Helena in March is the un-touristed real thing. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Delta Cultural Center, Cherry Street downtown bars (most are seasonal), Edwardian Inn for lodging-to-befriend. *Marketing story:* festival side-date pitch. Big Muddy routes acts to Helena for King Biscuit weekend, books them at the Blues Room the next night.

St. Francisville, LA — 21/25 2.5 hr drive south. Tiny, beautiful, B&B-dense, antebellum-walkable. The Inn-customer persona is already here. Magnolia Cafe is the local bar/restaurant anchor. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Magnolia Cafe (live music nights), Birdman Coffee, the Myrtles tavern, the Bird Man bar at the Saint. *Marketing story:* St. Francisville and Natchez are sister river towns; pitch the two-stop driving loop. Build referrals with three local B&Bs.

Baton Rouge, LA — 17/25 3 hr drive. State capital, university town (LSU), real audience but generic strip-mall surroundings. Phil Brady's Bar (Thursday blues jam, weekly, real). Chelsea's Live (mid-cap venue). *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Phil Brady's, Chelsea's, the bars off Government Street. *Marketing story:* Baton Rouge is functional, not romantic. Use it as a routing stop, don't lead with it editorially.

New Orleans, LA — 22/25 Corridor anchor south. 4 hr drive. Saturated music market, but the Big Muddy customer pool is enormous. Tipitina's, the Maple Leaf, Preservation Hall (Frenchmen St density). The play is not playing here — it's *being seen* here. One Frenchmen St night/quarter where the van is parked and Tracy + Amy hit four bars. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Cafe du Monde at 4am after the bars, Bacchanal in Bywater, Frenchmen St (Spotted Cat, d.b.a., Snug Harbor), Cafe Beignet. *Marketing story:* Natchez is the un-New-Orleans, 4 hours up the river, same culture, no crowd. That's a Magazine cover story.

TIER 2 — REGIONAL (COOL TOWNS WITHIN A DAY'S DRIVE)

Reachable in 4–8 hours. Worth a 2–3 night routing for the customer-pool yield.

Oxford, MS — 22/25 — 3.5 hr Faulkner's town, the Square, Ole Miss. Highest-density literary tourism in the state. Inn-customer persona walks the Square every weekend. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Square Books, City Grocery bar (upstairs), Proud Larry's (real music venue, college audience), Snackbar, Saint Leo. *Marketing story:* Oxford readers are Magazine readers. Pitch a literary angle on the Natchez–Oxford axis.

Florence/Muscle Shoals, AL — 23/25 — 5.5 hr FAME Studios, Muscle Shoals Sound. The mythic recording town. Not a venue town — it's a *story* town. The play is meeting the engineers and the studio operators. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* On the Rocks, Singin' River Brewing, Pegasus Records, the Stricklin Hotel bar. *Marketing story:* the house-band thesis Chase has been chasing. Big Muddy as the Muscle Shoals of the next era. Magazine piece pairs the two towns.

Tupelo, MS — 17/25 — 4.5 hr Elvis birthplace, blues anchor. Mid-size, walkable downtown, real local bars but light on the Big Muddy customer pool. Worth one routing/year for a festival or Elvis-week date. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Blue Canoe (live music), Bishop's BBQ, Reed's Gum Tree Bookstore. *Marketing story:* Tupelo as the un-Memphis. Use sparingly.

Athens, GA — 18/25 — 8 hr R.E.M. town, college music capital, real venue density (40 Watt Club). But it's an 8-hour haul and the customer pool is 22-year-olds who don't book inns. Worth one annual run only if paired with Asheville on the same swing. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* 40 Watt, Caledonia Lounge, the Manhattan Cafe, The Globe. *Marketing story:* light. Athens is for the Records side (signing acts) more than the Inn side.

Asheville, NC — 24/25 — 9 hr The single highest-yield Tier 2 stop. Lifestyle tourism overlap with the Inn customer is enormous. Brewery culture, walkable downtown, mountain-South aesthetic. The Orange Peel, Grey Eagle, Salvage Station are real venues. Inn-customer persona spends a week here every year. *Where Tracy + Amy go:*

Sovereign Remedies, the Crow & Quill, the Battery Park Book Exchange (champagne bar inside a bookstore), Buxton Hall, Cucina 24. *Marketing story*: Asheville people who want quieter should come to Natchez in the off-season. This is a quarterly Magazine pitch.

Marfa, TX — 19/25 — 14 hr (real haul) The art-destination sister vibe. Off-grid, weird, design-press darling. The BMA persona is here in surprising numbers. Not a music-tour stop — a *positioning* stop. Worth one annual van trip with the wrap as the entire point. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Lost Horse Saloon, Cochineal, the Capri, Hotel Saint George bar, Marfa Burrito. *Marketing story*: Marfa for Texans = Natchez for the South. Pitch the desert-vs-river twin-towns piece.

Austin, TX — 20/25 — 12 hr Real long drive, but the ecosystem-aligned audience is dense. The move is not playing here (Austin is saturated) — it's a 4-day "Big Muddy in Austin" trip during a non-SXSW week. Hit East Austin bars, meet the music people, be visible. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: The White Horse (East Side honky-tonk), C-Boy's Heart & Soul, the Continental Club, Hotel San Jose bar, Justine's. *Marketing story*: Austin's getting expensive. Natchez is the Austin of 1995. Pitch this hard.

TIER 3 — OFF THE BEATEN PATH (CHASE'S FILTER)

Small towns that punch above their weight. These are the towns the customer pool *wants to discover* — and what they read in the Magazine becomes the Inn booking three months later.

Natchitoches, LA — 21/25 — 4 hr Oldest permanent settlement in Louisiana Purchase. Cane River, brick streetscape, Northwestern State University. Christmas Festival of Lights pulls a real crowd. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Lasyone's Meat Pie Restaurant, Pioneer Pub, Mariner's Restaurant. *Customer fit*: perfect Inn persona — people who go to St. Francisville go here.

Eureka Springs, AR — 22/25 — 8.5 hr Victorian mountain town, weird and queer-friendly, hot springs, art-destination vibes. One of the most walkable downtowns in the South. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Chelsea's Corner Cafe (live music nightly), Brews, Mud Street Cafe, Crystal Dining Room at the Crescent Hotel. *Customer fit*: high — Inn persona, BMA-creative-class persona both present.

Marshall, TX — 16/25 — 7 hr East Texas, on the way to Marfa runs. Wonderland of Lights at Christmas. Small but characterful. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: OS2 (downtown bar), Central Perks. *Customer fit*: moderate. Use as a routing stop, not a destination.

Greenwood, MS — 19/25 — 2.5 hr The Alluvian Hotel (boutique, real, top-tier in the Delta). Viking Cooking School. Lusco's restaurant (legendary, century-old curtain-booth juke). Tallahatchie River. The customer pool here is direct overlap with the Inn. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Lusco's, the Alluvian bar, Giardina's, Crystal Grill. *Customer fit*: very high. The Alluvian's guests are the Inn's future guests. Befriend the GM.

Como, MS — 17/25 — 3.5 hr Tiny North Mississippi hill country town. Como Steakhouse, Hill Country Picnic music festival heritage. Otha Turner country. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Como Steakhouse (the bar), the Como Courtyard. *Customer fit*: niche. Magazine piece on hill country blues vs. Delta blues makes Como a stop.

Water Valley, MS — 18/25 — 4 hr North Mississippi, 25 minutes south of Oxford. Crawdad Hole, Yalo Studio & Gallery, Bozarts Gallery. Quiet artist-relocation town. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Crawdad Hole, Bozarts opening nights, Turnage Drug Store. *Customer fit*: high — exact BMA-creative-class persona profile. Real BMA prospect pool.

Holly Springs, MS — 16/25 — 5 hr Antebellum, R.L. Burnside country, Junior Kimbrough's juke heritage (now closed but the lineage is alive). Annual pilgrimage among architecture tourists. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Phillips Grocery, Town Square. *Customer fit*: moderate. Pair with Como/Water Valley on the same hill-country run.

Hot Springs, AR — 19/25 — 7 hr National park inside the city limits. Bathhouse Row. Superior Bathhouse Brewery. Real lodging-tourism market. *Where Tracy + Amy go*: Superior Bathhouse Brewery, Maxine's Live, the Ohio Club (oldest bar in AR, 1905). *Customer fit*: high — Inn persona overlaps directly.

Eufaula, AL — 14/25 — 7 hr Antebellum river town on the Chattahoochee. Beautiful but light commercial activity. Skip unless paired with Tuskegee or Selma routing. *Customer fit*: niche, low priority.

Selma, AL — 15/25 — 6 hr Historic weight, civil rights heritage. Light bar/restaurant infrastructure. Worth a single annual cultural-pilgrimage routing, not regular stops. *Customer fit*: low for Inn, moderate for Magazine editorial.

Bardstown, KY — 16/25 — 9 hr Bourbon trail anchor. Real but far. Worth pairing with a Louisville or Nashville run. *Customer fit*: high for Inn persona (bourbon tourists are inn tourists), but the drive math is brutal.

Berea, KY — 15/25 — 9 hr Appalachian crafts town, Berea College. *Customer fit*: niche craft-tourism overlap. Skip unless en route.

Beacon, NY — 17/25 — flight only, not Sprinter Hudson Valley sister town. DIA:Beacon. Creative-class transplant capital. *Customer fit*: very high — Tuthill region — but logistically a fly-in not a drive. Reframe as a Bearsville sub-route, not a Big Muddy van stop.

Tivoli + Hudson, NY — 17/25 — flight only Same logic. Bearsville feeder territory. Magazine cross-pollination is the real play, not Sprinter routing.

TIER 4 — BIG MARKETS (URBAN CUSTOMER POOLS, HARD VAN LOGISTICS)

Pick one per year. These are visibility plays, not booking plays.

Nashville, TN — 18/25 — 7 hr Industry density, but saturated. The play is meeting publishers and label people, not playing rooms. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* the Bluebird Cafe (legendary listening room), Robert's Western World, Santa's Pub, Dee's Country Cocktail Lounge. *Marketing story:* Big Muddy as the anti-Nashville. Pitch artists to come *out of* Nashville to record.

Atlanta, GA — 16/25 — 7 hr Southern capital, large customer pool, no walkable downtown for Tracy-and-Amy bar-crawl marketing. Sprawl works against us. Use sparingly. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* Manuel's Tavern, the Clermont Lounge. *Marketing story:* Atlanta money is buying second homes; Natchez is on the list.

Charleston, SC — 17/25 — 11 hr (real haul) Pure Inn-customer overlap, but the drive is brutal and Charleston is its own ecosystem. Worth one annual visit for inn-keeper relationship building. Don't tour bands here.

Savannah, GA — 17/25 — 9 hr Same logic as Charleston, slightly closer. *Where Tracy + Amy go:* the Crystal Beer Parlor, Pinkie Master's, Service Brewing taproom. *Marketing story:* Savannah-to-Natchez river-town axis is a Magazine piece.

Brooklyn / Hudson Valley — 15/25 — flight only Creative-class capital. Not a Big Muddy van trip. This is Tuthill/Bearsville territory. Cross-promotion only.

Los Angeles — 12/25 — flight only Industry. Not a Sprinter van trip ever. Worth one annual fly-in for label/management meetings. Skip from this map.

Routing logic — three multi-stop runs

ROUTE 1 — THE LOWER MISSISSIPPI LOOP (5–7 DAYS)

Sequence: Natchez → Vicksburg → Greenville → Clarksdale → Helena → Memphis → back south to Natchez via Highway 61. **Van miles:** ~800 round trip. **Fuel cost:** ~\$220 (Sprinter at ~18 mpg, \$4/gal). **Lodging strategy:** Befriend the Shack Up Inn in Clarksdale (reciprocal referral target). Edwardian Inn in Helena. Boutique hotel in Memphis (research target — possibly the Big Cypress Lodge in Bass Pro or the Hu Hotel; befriending, don't compete). **Per night for Tracy + Amy:** 2 bars minimum, 1 restaurant. Vicksburg = 10 South + Walnut Hills. Clarksdale = Ground Zero + Red's. Memphis = Hi-Tone + Earnestine & Hazel's. **Marketing yield:** highest on the map. Every stop is a Magazine subject and a referral relationship. Route this every quarter.

ROUTE 2 — THE EASTWARD SWING (NASHVILLE → ASHEVILLE → ATHENS → HOME, 7–10 DAYS)

Sequence: Natchez → Tupelo (overnight) → Nashville → Asheville (2 nights) → Athens → Atlanta (light, drive-through) → home via Birmingham. **Van miles:** ~2,000 round trip. **Fuel cost:** ~\$550. **Lodging strategy:** Tupelo = Hilton Garden or befriend a B&B. Nashville = Urban Cowboy or the Bobby Hotel (befriend, not compete). Asheville = the Foundry Hotel or befriend the Sourwood Inn. Athens = the Graduate or Holiday Inn (skip the boutique angle here, college town). **Per night for Tracy + Amy:** 2 bars/night minimum. Asheville is the high-yield night — hit Sovereign Remedies, Crow & Quill, and the Battery Park Book Exchange in one swing. **Marketing yield:** Asheville is the conversion engine. Nashville is the relationship engine. Route this twice a year.

ROUTE 3 — THE TEXAS / PLAINS RUN (MARFA → AUSTIN → MARSHALL → HOME, 5–7 DAYS)

Sequence: Natchez → Marshall, TX (overnight) → Austin (2 nights) → Marfa (2 nights) → back via Marshall or skip-stop. **Van miles:** ~2,400 round trip. **Fuel cost:** ~\$650. **Lodging strategy:** Marshall = befriend a small inn or roadside motel (low priority). Austin = the Hotel San Jose or Carpenter Hotel (befriend, model for what the Inn could be). Marfa = the Hotel Saint George or El Cosmico (the latter is the BMA infrastructure twin — befriend hard). **Per night:** Austin = the White Horse + C-Boy's. Marfa = Lost Horse + the Capri. **Marketing yield:** highest *positioning* yield on the map. The Sprinter parked in front of El Cosmico is a Magazine cover. Route this once a year, in spring or fall (avoid Texas summer).

The marketing flywheel — how each stop feeds back

Every tour stop generates four kinds of return:

Magazine — Tracy's editorial beat. One destination = one feature piece minimum. The Magazine's editorial calendar should be set by the Sprinter's route, not the other way around. A Vicksburg run in May = a Vicksburg cover story in July. The Magazine isn't the marketing of the towns; it's the marketing of *the corridor as a unit*, with the towns as proof.

Inn — Build reciprocal referral relationships at one boutique inn per town. We send our overflow to them; they send theirs to us. By end of Y1, a mapped network of 8–12 friendly inns (Shack Up, Alluvian, Edwardian, El Cosmico, Hotel San Jose, Sourwood, Magnolia Cafe rooms, etc.). That network is the Inn's distribution channel.

Records / Touring — Every artist Tracy and Amy meet at Phil Brady's in Baton Rouge or the 40 Watt in Athens is a Records signing candidate or a Blues Room booking. The bar friendships ARE the A&R pipeline.

BMA — Every cool town visit is land scouting and customer scouting. Eureka Springs has retirees who'd buy a BMA pad. Marfa has the design DNA we're cribbing for the BMA aesthetic. Water Valley, MS has the artist-relocation persona ready to convert. Tracy and Amy meet 5 plausible BMA leads per trip if they're paying attention.

Outsider Economics — Every stop is editorial subject matter. Small towns surviving (or not) is the magazine's beat. The reporting writes itself.

The weekly cadence question

The honest math: Tracy and Amy can't be on the road every week. The Inn needs presence, Amy's residency at the Blues Room is the controlled floor (per the touring plan), and the corridor doesn't fill if the home base is empty.

Realistic rhythm:

- **Same-day trips (Vicksburg, St. Francisville, Greenwood):** weekly is plausible. Drive up, hit two bars, drive home. No overnight.
- **Tier 1 corridor runs (Clarksdale, Memphis, NOLA):** monthly. Two nights out, three at most. Sprinter van fully loaded. Always paired with a touring artist Big Muddy is routing, so the trip pays for itself in booking yield.
- **Tier 2 regional swings (Asheville, Florence, Oxford):** quarterly. 4–7 night trips. Plan around Inn occupancy lulls.
- **Tier 3 long hauls (Marfa, Austin, Eureka Springs):** annual. Once a year per route.
- **Tier 4 visibility trips (Nashville, Atlanta, Charleston):** annual at most. Strategic, not routine.

Who goes:

- Tracy + Amy as the default duo (the bar-friendship marketing is a two-person play, not solo).
- Chase joins for Tier 4 industry trips (Nashville, Austin) where the relationships are commercial.
- JP (when his role finalizes — not named publicly per CLAUDE.md) handles solo Sprinter runs to drop off touring acts and pick up.
- Arrie Aslin tours separately on her own performance schedule; the marketing trips are *not* her tour, they're the marketing apparatus around her.

Never on the road simultaneously: Tracy and Amy *and* the Sprinter. If the Sprinter is dropping Arrie at a date, Tracy and Amy fly or drive a separate vehicle. The van is the billboard; it should always be deployed.

What this map is not

It's not a music-business tour itinerary. We are not optimizing for ticket revenue per night. We are optimizing for the Big Muddy ecosystem's customer acquisition cost. A night with no music revenue but two new boutique-inn referral relationships is a winning night.

It's not a comprehensive list of every Southern music town. Memphis to NOLA has 50 plausible stops. We picked the ones that score on the *customer* dimension, not just the music dimension.

It's not locked. Tracy and Amy will discover bars and people on the road that change the rankings. The map updates monthly.

End of map. Next step: Chase, Tracy, and Amy review the Tier 1 list and confirm the first quarterly Lower Mississippi loop dates. Magazine editorial calendar gets set against the route, not the other way around.